—move forward and away from him.

"*Vos papiers, mademoiselle, s'il vous plait*."

She opened her purse, reached for her papers, and handed them to the gendarme.

"Who did you come here with?"

"No one," she said, swallowing. "I'm alone."

The gendarmes exchanged a look, and for a moment, she almost wished they wouldn't believe her and arrest her, too. At least that way, she could be with André for a few more hours, maybe days or weeks. But that wouldn't be fair to Léa—she had to help her sister. There seemed to be nothing she could now do for André.

"Let's bring him to the station," one of the gendarmes said, glancing back at André. "Put him in the back of the truck."

The gendarme, still holding her documents, pushed André out the door. Rose hesitated. She couldn't let her papers go. She tried to speak, but shock locked her in place. She stood frozen, her voice momentarily gone.

"Hold on," André said, turning back. "That young lady needs her documents."

The gendarme glared at him and then at Rose. "Do you know this man?" he asked her.

"No, I don't." She knew she had to sound confident, though it tore her heart. She could still feel André's imprint on her hand, giving her courage. "Please, can I have my identity papers back?"

The gendarme sighed and threw them at her, though they landed on the floor. Rose bent down to pick them up. "Thank you," she said.

In her heart, she'd spoken those words to André, and she was sure he knew that in the way he smiled as he looked back at her before he was turned to face the front. She lifted her chin, watching him leave, vowing to herself that this would not be the last time she saw André. That no matter what it took, she would find him again.

* * *

As Rose reached the boardinghouse, guilt and fear twisted through her body like a tangible force. She was eager to speak with Léa, hoping that Maître Mallon might know someone who could help André. She clung to the belief